



In the zone: Tejaswin in action during the javelin throw and the 1500m (below) decathlon events. ASIAN ATHLETICS

and the mood was tense. Everyone was quiet, in their heads, calculating the permutations — times, medals, margins. Bags were packed. Nothing more to do but run.

And then, the skies opened.

A torrential downpour — not a drizzle, not a shower, but a full-on tropical storm. It was so bad the organisers *stopped the women's 10,000m race mid-run*. I've never seen that in my life — not even in a school meet. It felt surreal.

Luckily, the rain let up just in time for our start. No delay. We were ready to be done.

With Yuma having pulled out

earlier due to injury, four of us remained in medal contention: India, China, Taiwan, and Japan.

The equation was clear.

For India to medal, I just had to finish ahead of Taiwan and Japan. For India to win gold, I had to beat the Chinese athlete by 10 seconds.

It was an easy decision: **all or nothing.**

I already had a medal from the last edition. This time, only gold would be enough to cap off the Asian Championships the way I had dreamed. Before the race, I made a point to thank every decathlete. Once this race ended, we would all go our

separate ways — but until then, we were brothers. Win or lose, we had fought together. And I was grateful.

The race began. I surged to the front right from the gun. I was going for it.

My legs started dying around the 1km mark, but my spirit was soaring. I was running for something bigger than points — for the effort, for the journey, for the people who had carried me here.

I crossed the line in **4:37** and turned around, eyes locked on the track.

1... 2... 3... 4... 5... 6... 7 seconds.

The Chinese athlete crossed. I needed **10**.

I had missed gold by **3 seconds** — just **16 points**.

But in that moment, that wasn't what I thought about first. My instinct was to embrace every single athlete at the finish line. They were all winners — not winners of medals, but conquerors of their own fear, doubts, and inner demons that haunted us across these two days.

My silver was confirmed. After the usual photos with the national flag, a few minutes with my support team, the Indian coaches, and the athletes who cheered me on, I returned to the resting area.

As I sat down, processing it all, my thoughts drifted to Yuma — lying quietly in a corner with his team doctors. He wasn't in pain from injury — it was the heartbreak. A gold medal that should've been his, taken not by a competitor, but by fate.

I realised then: my medal wasn't complete without acknowledging his impact. I wrote him a letter — not just for him, but for myself. To thank him. For pushing me. For being the standard. For reminding me that real heroes don't wear capes. They fight. And whether they win or lose, they leave it all on the field.

Post-decathlon action

My competition was over. The emotions had settled, the celebrations were done, and my body was in a million pieces — but my soul was content.

Yet the Asian Championships were far from finished. For TJ the athlete, yes — but not for TJ the lifelong track

